Western backers, especially the USA. In the years ahead, the vacuum left by Arab nationalism was to be filled by radical or **political Islam**, sometimes called **Islamic fundamentalism**.

Key terms

Political Islam
A political movement which asserts that Islam is the solution to the problems of the modern world. Its followers advocate Islamic states where the Koran is the basis of government and society.

Islamic fundamentalism
The belief that the state should be based wholly on Islamic law, as in Muhammad's day.

Jihad
An Arabic word meaning 'struggle', both internal and personal (against sin) and external (against threats to Muslim lands).

Political Islam or Islamic fundamentalism

At the heart of this movement was the belief that Muslims (and nearly all Arabs are Muslims) should return to their Islamic values and establish states based on laws derived from the Koran, the Muslim holy book. The followers of this radical, political Islam believed that, through Islam, they could best unify, strengthen and defend themselves against the military and economic power of the West. Israel, of course, was seen as part of the West, regarded as a foreign, non-Muslim state carved out of Arab lands by the West.

The followers of political Islam are sometimes called fundamentalists because they believe that the state should be based *wholly*, or fundamentally, on Islamic law, as in Muhammad's day, and all changes introduced from the West should be eliminated. In practice, it was unlikely that such a fundamentalist regime would ever be implemented: even the most radical or extreme Islamists have made use of Western inventions like the Internet, for example.

Arab nationalism had accepted the special place of Islam in the life of most Arabs but not in the political life of the nation. Arab nationalists put more stress on their common language, Arabic, and on their historical ties than they did on religion as a unifying force for the Arabs. Arab nationalism was, essentially, secular. By contrast, radical Islamic groups wanted no division between political and religious life, between religion and government. They stressed the importance of Islam in renewing their societies and enabling them to resist the domination of the West. Political Islam thrived, above all, because it was the most potent protest movement and was the first home-grown ideology in the Arab world. Many followers of political Islam believed in ***jihad***, an Arabic word meaning 'struggle'. Its primary meaning, as used in the Koran, is the internal struggle against sin or bad habits (whether the personal struggle of the individual or that of the Islamic community). It is also used to mean the struggle to defend Muslim lands from external aggression.

Political Islam was not only a challenge to foreign, non-Muslim powers. It was also, like Arab nationalism, a challenge to the governments of Muslim countries. Several Arab countries, in particular, felt threatened, just as they had been by Arab nationalism. Again, the countries who felt most threatened were the more conservative monarchies like Saudi Arabia and Jordan and those with the closest ties to the West. Some of the smaller, oil-rich states in the Gulf, like Kuwait, were ruled by rich élites who did not wish to lose their power to the Muslim clergy. Egypt, under Nasser's successor, Anwar Sadat, also felt the pressure. This was particularly so after Sadat had made peace with Israel in 1978. He was seen to have broken the united front